

Project Study: How Everyday Use of AI Is Changing the Way We Build Skills and Expertise

KfW Banking Group

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Company Description

Responsible banking

KfW is one of the world's leading promotional banks. KfW has been committed to improving economic, social and environmental living conditions across the globe on behalf of the Federal Republic of Germany and the federal states since 1948. To do this, it provided funds totalling EUR 112.8 billion in 2024 alone.

A mandate to promote global development

KfW does not have any branches and does not hold customer deposits. To refinance its business activities, KfW raised funds totalling around EUR 71 billion on the international capital markets in 2025 - EUR 14 billion of which through 'Green Bonds - Made by KfW'.

At its headquarters in Frankfurt am Main, at its two branches in Berlin and Bonn, at its subsidiaries KfW IPEX-Bank, DEG and KfW Capital, it employs 9,137 members of staff (as of 2025). It is represented at around 80 locations worldwide.

As a bank committed to responsibility, KfW supports people, countries and institutions who think ahead, driving our society towards the future. This profile is what clearly sets KfW apart from other commercial banks.

Background

AI assistants are becoming part of everyday work life. They boost productivity but also encourage people to take shortcuts and engage less deeply with content (cognitive offloading).

True expertise is traditionally developed through effortful, sometimes arduous practice and engagement—and it is precisely these steps that are at risk of being skipped in an AI-driven work environment. Young professionals and early-career employees, who are just beginning to build their expertise, are particularly affected.

For an institution whose management and oversight (risk, credit, compliance, dual control/HITL) rely on employees capable of sound judgment, genuine competency development is not just an HR issue but also a governance issue.

Problem Definition

This project study examines how the everyday use of AI influences adult learning and the development of genuine expertise, both in terms of subject matter and with regard to judgment and personal development (education, not just training) , with a focus on young professionals and early-career employees. The study does not require any internal KfW data and relies exclusively on public sources and qualitative assessments.

The students

- (a) synthesize the current state of research in cognitive and learning sciences and L&D (cognitive offloading, desirable difficulties, deliberate practice, metacognition);
- (b) identify which roles, entry-level profiles, and competencies are particularly threatened by “learning complacency,” and include the further development of existing competencies as a secondary strand;
- (c) develop several scenarios for the future quality of competencies and the next generation of talent;
- (d) derive concrete recommendations for action on how companies can structure work, learning, and AI use so that productivity and genuine competency development go hand in hand (“productive friction by design,” AI guidelines tailored to career levels, genuine competency assessment, redesign of trainee/apprenticeship programs).

Methodology: Review of the current state of public research (literature synthesis) + 8–12 qualitative expert interviews (L&D/HR development, apprenticeship/trainee programs, executives, and, where applicable, trainees/junior staff).

Result: A clear analysis with scenarios and a practical set of recommendations (L&D/HR playbook) for KfW.

Project Study Tasks/Assignment

Work on a **highly relevant** and **strategic project** with **impact**

The task of the project study: To develop a playbook as the primary outcome. The goal is not to deliver a fully developed solution, but to create a tangible, testable set of recommendations that demonstrates the core idea and enables validation, feedback, and further development.



You will work directly with a contact person of the company & be supervised by the chair of Entrepreneurship and Family Enterprise



Benefits for students: Gain practical experience in literature synthesis and qualitative research, enhance analytical and problem-solving skills, and build a strong portfolio through real-world personnel development challenges.



Requirements and Information

Skills: Interest in the Future of Work, learning and cognitive science, and human resources development/L&D; ability to conduct structured literature reviews and qualitative research (expert interviews); analytical conceptual skills; interest in organizational and governance issues in a regulated environment. German language skills are a plus for interviews.

Language: German / English

Group Size: 2 - 5 Students

General Information: [kfw.de](https://www.kfw.de)

Application Process

*If you are interested in participating in the project study, please send the following application documents **per Email** to **Lorenz Tidow**:*

- (1) Letter of Motivation*
- (2) CV*
- (3) Transcript of Records*
- (4) Indicate Project Study of Interest*

Project Start: Mid November 2026

*Application Deadline: End of October
2026*



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